

Josephine Auer

MIT Department of Economics, Cambridge, MA

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Research Fields

Primary: Microeconomic Theory, Behavioural Economics

Secondary: Industrial Organisation, Organisational Economics

Education

Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)

Cambridge, MA

PhD in Economics, expected 2031

Current cumulative graduate GPA: 5.0/5.0

Kenan Sahin Presidential Fellow

University of Oxford

Oxford, UK

MPhil in Economics, 2023–2025

Distinction

Rhodes Scholar (Queensland and Magdalen College), University of Oxford

The University of Queensland

Brisbane, Australia

Bachelor of Mathematics, 2022 (GPA: 7.0/7.0)

Bachelor of Advanced Finance and Economics (Honours Class I), 2019 (GPA: 7.0/7.0)

Vice Chancellor's Scholar

Graduate Coursework

MIT Fall 2025 (completed):

14.164 Foundations of Behavioural Economics (A), 14.281 Contract Economics (A), ECON2059 Decision Theory (A), 14.271 Industrial Organisation I (listener)

MIT Spring 2026 (completed):

14.163 Algorithms and Behavioural Science, 14.283 Advanced Topics in Organisational Economics I, 14.284 Advanced Topics in Organisational Economics II, 14.126 Game Theory (listener), 14.273 Advanced Topics in Industrial Organisation (listener)

Research Papers

Under review

- *When Does Static Willingness to Pay Mislead? A Framework for Dynamic Hedonic Valuation*
- *A Secret Worth Keeping? Bid Cap Design in Budget-Constrained Procurement Auctions* (with Lana Friesen and Ian A. MacKenzie)

Research in Progress

- *Product Representation Strategy: Demand, Attention, and Firm Communication*: a structural rational inattention demand model separating product attributes from firm representations, with an empirical application to panel data on packaged-food purchases.
- *Persuasion Through Public Deliberation*: a sequential persuasion model in which public histories generate social-image payoffs, endogenous scrutiny costs, and inefficient information aggregation.
- *AI Assistance and Misperceived Learning*: an experiment identifying whether AI assistance distorts beliefs about human capital accumulation by inducing overprediction of later unaided performance (with Eric Gao).
- *Commitment Cascades*: a model of delayed commitment demand in which naive present-biased agents update from failed intentions, generating cross-environment cascades in sophistication and commitment take-up (with Eric Gao).
- *AI and Skill Development in Frontline Health Work*: an experiment separating contemporaneous AI productivity effects from persistent human-capital accumulation among frontline health workers (with Madhavi Jha and Lauren Rice).
- *Diagnosing Behavioural Hazard in the Age of Algorithms*: hypothesis generation from patient–chatbot data on behavioural frictions in the take-up of high-value medical care (with Zachary Wojtowicz).
- *Aggregate Rationalisability for Collective AI Systems*: a label-free revealed-preference audit of whether aggregate AI recommendations admit coherent latent role-level rationalisations.
- *Modern Slavery*: a decision-theoretic model of risky migration and trafficking vulnerability under uncertainty (with Ian Jewitt).

Selected Policy Research Outputs

- Auer, J. (2022), *Disengaged: The costs and possible causes of youth disengagement in Australia*, e61 Research Note Series.
- Andrews, D., Auer, J., Elias, M., La Cava, G., and Mercier, L. (2022), *The effect of the COVID-19 recession on the youth labour market in Australia*, e61 Institute.
- Adams, N., Andrews, D., Auer, J., Clarke, E., Hayward, Z., La Cava, G., and Nolan, M. (2022), *Preventing scarring in the post-pandemic youth labour market*, e61 Institute.
- Adams, N., Andrews, D., Auer, J., Dwyer, E., Hayward, Z., Kaplan, G., La Cava, G., Michielsen, A., and Nolan, M. (2022), *Better harnessing Australia’s talent: five facts for the Summit*, e61 Institute.

Research Experience

University of Oxford, Economics of Modern Slavery Initiative Research Contributor	2024–present
e61 Institute Predoctoral Analyst	2022–2023
The University of Queensland, School of Economics Economics Research Assistant	2019–2022

Selected Honours and Awards

Kenan Sahin Presidential Fellowship, MIT, 2025–present

Rhodes Scholarship (Queensland), Oxford, 2023

University Medal, UQ, 2020

UQ Graduate of the Year, UQ, 2020

Valedictorian, UQ School of Economics, 2019

Vice Chancellor's Scholarship, UQ, 2016–2022